

Drama Online

rehearsal process is always dependent on the material that we start to work with
and um
sometimes it's a play uh sometimes it's just an idea some it's always some kind of a
text
but uh
it can be a play or it can be just a documentary material
or it can be writing of some other kind
so if it's a play
it's very simple
I never read it before um I get go into rehearsal
I decide on it
either because somebody wants to do it in the company
or someone's told me we should do it
because it would be right for us
or we could get money
for it
something like like that
or I've I've heard about it or I read it when I was very young
something like that
and then I I get together and we read it with the company
or whoever we get to to come
and I don't go back and read it on my own I get another bunch of people maybe
together or smaller cast or we read it again same people
and then um
by that time I'll have a a vision of how to um stage it
that comes first
I'll have some idea of the style how I want to hear it or how I don't want to hear it
uh sometimes **it's just the negative**
I want to find some new way of hearing it that I don't even know about
um and then we start it's a play we start
by trying to Stage it
but I have usually two or maybe sometimes three ideas in mind at the same time
and they don't they don't
um what's the word I'm looking for
they don't augment each other or they don't illuminate each other
they're two totally separate ideas
like for one play um for fedra I had an idea I was really interested in um 30s and 50s
architecture in America mainly in the west coast
just for structure H
so I wanted to make this space into that structure and then fit the script into
that how would people move in that space
so uh and I wasn't thinking oh this is the right text for that or it's not the right text I I I
don't even think about that right away
and then I had a third thing for that text for instance that was
I had so much work to do on to figure out what the voice of the text was
that I needed time time to think and just watch people on stage
so if I do that

I just invent a game or a structure or something
usually some kind of a
I don't know
some kind of a it's usually some kind of a sport
for that one it was um pingpong which became bad
uh so that I can watch them and put music to it
just doing something on the stage while I can think
you know because I get so nervous when they have to just stare at me and I don't
have anything
so that usually that's usually there for just about every piece
there's something that I give them to do
so I can watch them in the space
INTERLOCUTION a game or an activity
yes or an activity or yeah it doesn't have to be a game
it's not a game so much as a a series of actions
that they have to do
that have nothing to do with the text
usually
they don't
at the end they they uh join into the text in a nice way
if we work long enough
it works itself together
uh and then I have another uh this other area of sound
that that I'm always interested in
I'm interested in some kind of music
and sometimes it comes from the text but usually it doesn't
usually it's something I'm interested in
like for this last piece the Pinter
I was really interested in this Chinese music
because we just been to China
so um that was over here
and then the physical structure was from a Chinese
um
comedy form called um cross talk not in American but cross talk
so I had that structure of cross talk
and how they had to um imitate
or simulate
uh that structure on the stage
uh and then the text
and so I I work those three things
and I think a lot of that's just intuition
it doesn't have to do with it's not as if I go
ah I want this
but it's things that are interesting me and they seem to come together
because I have the space and the time
you know it's a real luxury
you know the only thing I don't have is money
I have plenty of time and space I start to um combine and a place and combine in
the space

it's like working
probably I mean I only hear and see in three dimensions
so I can't really hear something flat
I have to hear it in the space and I can't
and I get them on their feet almost immediately
we don't do any um analysis of the text
uh in the traditional way
I mean we do talk about it like we'll read stuff
today we're we're working on something
today that's about it's a feminist
uh panel from from the 1970s
early '70s
and we we spent a good deal of time
reading um this um baudrillard thing
and it's just cuz I found it over there
when I was going through some of my things to throw away
and it links up and but it will never be in the peace
so there's a lot of that time
you know because we have that kind of time
people bring things in
we talk about politics
we usually talk about what's happening before we start
I don't know why we're just social
everybody be social
and then that all feeds into the world
but pretty organically
so the big thing for me is it's I don't have a system
I probably do
but I don't want to know what it is
because I go in trying to say
I mean I don't have to try
I don't know what the script's about
I didn't
I wasn't in theater so most of the things people bring me I have no idea
I heard that about that play and I have to kind of figure out what it is for me
because I don't see theater as a literary art
I see it as a it is a collaboration between the the director the performers and the
writer
and how you balance that is extremely important to me
all three things are extremely important
but it is not a literary activity
it's an event

accompany people
who are committing themselves to the project for that moment
that time
totally committing
and who
they don't have to trust me

because I've or many people didn't trust me but went along for other reasons
it's great
no problem
as long as we can come to something
but it has to be um
I have to be able to work with
the sound the video the lighting
and the performers
all at the same time
because we make the pieces
I don't make them separately
the technical people are working in the same way as the performers
so when we make something
we try to make the whole mix
usually I think what happens is
a score is added on later
for me I make the score the sound score with the sound guys at the same time as
I'm making the oral score
yeah I need that
they have to be there
in the space
I don't ever know that they're right I just know they're there
they made a commitment to be there that's all
CU if I got everybody that was right
I can't imagine that there's no I mean theater is about conflict
and I I depend on that
I depend on people being in the space who are going to say I can't do that or I don't
know that or you're wrong
I depend on that because it forces me to um I don't go back on myself because I
would be so bored
I mean I've made I don't know 60 pieces
I would have been so bored by the 10th piece
that I would have
I don't know I would have done what uh what's his name dude
I qu I have quit theater
what keeps me going is that I never know who's going to say no
and then I'm going to have to deal with it so um
yeah it's just the need of that now
because I'm always having that and it's very exciting
it's also frustrating but it's very exciting
in the end
it's not a family
well maybe it is because we don't all get along
and we don't really all socialize very much
but when we come together
it's very clear we're there for the duration

uh losing losing some
of we lose I lose people all the time

uh it comes up all the time
and it's always a problem
that I've trained somebody quote unquote
because I don't really train someone we find some kind of way of working together
that's fantastic it's working great
and they want to go on and make their own work
or they want to go and do films
or they want you know or they want to
and it's like I never say you have to stay I would never I never make any contracts
with anybody
they can go anytime they want
um but that's always a Readjustment to a new person coming in
but in the end I think it's what's kept me alive
you know because they come in with new material that I have to so I have to rethink
everything
and find what they're what they are
and that changes the work it changes me
so it's hard but it's not
it's not fatal

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iwnqoL0mZnQ>
Elizabeth LeCompte on her work with The Wooster Group